

International Management Institute: “I believe that with the business opportunities that are there, India Inc. is going to thrive. Take the example of the Tata Group’s acquisition of JLR (Jaguar Land Rover). “There was some initial resistance, but then it died down because they (opponents) also realised that no other company is going to invest and that JLR has to survive, especially since lots of people have their livelihood at stake.” In these groups, professional leaders like N. Chandrasekaran (Tata), Anish Shah of M&M and Gopal Vittal of Bharti demonstrated that not only could they deliver results but also command the trust of all stakeholders.

Nikhil Prasad Ojha, Partner & Head of Strategy Practice, Asia-Pacific, Bain & Company, says, “In India, conglomerates outperformed pureplay companies because they made changes in their portfolio mix (entering new, high-growth sectors and exiting some old ones) and exited via bankruptcies. Conglomerates also enjoy a cushion against downturns.”

CLARITY OF PURPOSE

Relatively mid-level business families like the Bhartias of Jubilant and DCM Shriram restarted on a clean slate after family feuds. Non-family groups like ITC and L&T diversified into new areas and succeeded.

Beyond ambition and growth, many of these groups have a clear purpose, which helped them in building their reputation, and social commitment.

The Tatas stayed true to the group’s articulated responsibility towards society and nation. Two-thirds of Tata Sons’ equity is held



“The sheer gravitas and vision of leaders who wanted to make contributions in every field led to the growth of Indian conglomerates”

**PROFESSOR
CHANDRASHEKHAR
SRIPADA**

Clinical Professor (OB),
Indian School of Business



“We do not know right now how it (AI) will play out. It is an opportunity and a threat. But one thing we know: it will be disruptive”

HITESH OBEROI
Co-promoter, Managing
Director and CEO,
Info Edge

by the non-profit Tata Trusts, which funnels funds into 15 areas from education to nutrition and environment to energy.

Project Nanhi Kali, founded in 1996 at K.C. Mahindra Education Trust by Anand Mahindra, envisioned a world where girls, despite patriarchal challenges and societal biases, are empowered through education. Since 1996, this project has covered 870,000 girls.

The ₹10,000 crore DS Group champions the role of women both within its corporate structure and through extensive community initiatives, demonstrating a commitment to gender equity.

STRATEGIC REDIRECTION

Beyond leadership, strategy and the ability to implement strategy successfully is an important precondition to conglomerate growth. And diversification, both related and unrelated, is a key factor.

Since Anand Mahindra took the reins of M&M from his uncle Keshub Mahindra, he has redirected the group from automobiles, tractors and farm machinery to finance, hospitality, real estate, agriculture, renewables, defence and digital.

DS Group’s diversification is primarily rooted in leveraging its strengths in flavours, fragrances, and knowledge of Indian consumers and their taste buds. Most of its businesses are natural extensions of its expertise; it ventured into hospitality when it acquired a hotel in 2000.

Says Rajiv Kumar, Vice Chairman, DS Group: “The DS Group maintains a clear focus on its core strengths, expanding mainly within food and FMCG verticals where it has established expertise